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Chapter 3

Learning in early childhood

Early childhood is the time when the human being first experiences society and undergoes a tremendous amount of learning, and so I have included a brief chapter about early childhood in order to lay the foundations for the remainder of the book. This is probably the period in life (the first three years) when the most learning actually occurs, and so it is necessary when we consider lifelong learning to recognise this – adult educators should consider this period in seeking to understand adult learning but, likewise, childhood educators should, I think, also look at the whole of life. In this chapter we will meet many of the issues with which we will be confronted later in the book since early childhood learning underlies a great deal of our later living. The chapter is divided into five sections – the primacy of relationship, learning and the senses, play, language and socialisation – and it will conclude with a brief discussion on the first years.

Part 1: The primacy of relationship

Enlightenment thought emphasised the individual, reflecting the West's Judeo-Christian and Greek heritage, although it apparently jettisoned a great deal of the former, whereas Eastern thought has always emphasised the harmony of the whole and the individual's place within it. There have, however, always been thinkers from the Judeo-Christian heritage who have placed relationship at the forefront of their thinking, but they have not achieved the prominence that perhaps they have merited. In the following paragraphs we will focus on some of these.

Paradoxically, if we try to start with the individual in the beginning of life, we fail to find the individual – since from the moment of our conception we are totally contained within our mother's womb. From that time there is life and relationship but there is no knowable individuality in the womb itself, so that Martin Buber (1958) could rightly claim that in the beginning is relationship. From the outset of our lives we are dependent upon our mothers, but this relationship appears to be much more complex than originally imagined. In research with monkeys, for instance, Harlow and Mears (1979; cited in Wexler, 2006) concluded that even the provision of milk was not the end in itself for the mother's provision but that the provision of milk fosters the mother–child relationship and it is this relationship that is important for the child's future development. During these interactions children learn both awareness and attention. Donald (2001) makes a significant point about this relationship in the light of the current debates about the existence of consciousness when he asks how the relationship between mother and child can continue when all the cells from each body (mother's and child's) change over time but the relationship remains.

Significantly, it is in this relationship that bonding between mother and child occurs, and this is the beginning of a relationship of love, to which we will return when we discuss questions of universal ethic (Chapter 15). However, there is another aspect of this relationship that is important, because the child learns to trust the mother for the provision of

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food and drink. Trust and therefore a sense of faith emerges in this relationship – another aspect of human living to which we will return when we look at believing and the growth of faith. All of these vital elements of human living are learned pre-consciously.

We are interconnected with other people from the outset of our own lives; from the earliest moments after birth, young babies seek and experience relationship with their parents – so-called 'protoconversations' (Tomasello, 1999: 59), in which young children mimic the behaviour of their carers. Imitation is a fundamental method of learning throughout life, and it begins almost with the onset of life outside the womb. But as we grow our sphere of relationship broadens: I relate to other people – both face to face and later through other media; I relate to the external natural world; but I also relate to my previous experiences, my memories of those experiences, and so on, so that I relate to myself. In Buber's terms, the interpersonal living relationship is *I–Thou* whereas we have *I–It* and *I–Me* relationships, as we saw in the previous chapter. Whereas I, as learner, learn through all the relationships, the first (*I–Thou*) is a living personal relationship. Indeed, Buber actually calls the *I–Thou* relationship a primary word – a unity. And it is significant that many years later Ogden (1986: 171; cited in Wexler, 2006: 124) actually says that 'It is … the mother–infant that is the unit of psychological development'. Nevertheless, every experience must just precede our awareness of it by nanoseconds, although we feel that it is completely simultaneous and in the present: this I will call here the 'experienced present'. The third relationship is different – *I–Me* – but in it there is a sense in which my memories, my life history and so on appear objective in the self. In this sense it is also an *I–It* relationship since it is only through objectification of my own life that I can understand myself, and I do this in the present. This three-way relationship is simultaneous and it can transcend immediate time. Buber actually adds a fourth relationship – one with spiritual beings – but I have no intention of entering this contentious subject here as it would lead us away from our central theme, although we will examine learning both spirituality and religion in this book. Buber (1958: 51) goes on to claim the following:

> Individuality makes its appearance by being differentiated from other individualities. A person makes his appearance by entering a relationship with other persons.

In a similar manner another philosopher, MacMurray (1979 [1961]: 91), captured the emerging individual in relationship:

> the development of the individual person is the development of his individual relation to the Other. Personal individuality is not an original given fact. It is achieved through the progressive differentiation of the original unity of the 'You and I'.

Children discover their individuality only by progressively differentiating themselves from their mothers and their families. The reason for this, MacMurray adduces, is because we are accustomed to start with the ideas of reflection rather than those that come from action but, as he argues, persons are agents so that we have to start with action. We will also make this point very clearly when we discuss learning and everyday life. Significantly, however, this is also the issue between situation and understanding and the reverse process of moving from understanding to situation.

Relationship precedes individuality and in this sense there is a primacy of relationship.

But that primacy is even more significant in the conception and growth of the fetus and also the development of the brain in the earliest months after birth. The fetus's senses function as they develop in the womb, so that pre-conscious and pre-cognitive learning occur weeks before birth. Tremlin writes:

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> As early as the first trimester of a pregnancy, the fetus already possesses centers of balance and motion that respond to the mother's own movements. At the halfway point of gestation a fetus can hear. Sight remains severely muted; unlike the sense of hearing, there are few external stimuli in the uterus. But by the seventh month the eyelids are open and the fetus can see by diffused light coming through the abdominal wall. Taste, too, is working as the fetus takes in the amniotic fluid. In addition to these basic functions of sense and motor control, there is also clear evidence that the brain is busy *learning* in the womb. One example utilizes the fetus' well-developed sense of hearing. Clever experiments that chart the rhythm sucks on a rubber nipple reveal preferences for a mother's voice and other patterns of sound heard in the womb.
>
> (Tremlin, 2006: 51, italics in original)

I well recall teaching an adult class in Alaska when we were discussing pre-conscious learning and a pregnant First Nation woman told the class that her people taught mothers-to-be to talk to their babies in the womb. Fetuses learn by sense experience in the womb in a pre-conscious and pre-cognitive manner but the status of that learning is less clear. Are the outcomes knowledge or tacit or potential knowledge? Do they predetermine the outcomes of future learning or do they merely influence them?

Indeed, it might well be claimed that the universality of the drum beat reflects the pre-conscious learning of the mother's heart beat learned pre-consciously in the womb. However, Dennett (1999; cited in Blackmore, 2007: 11) used a similar example of the heart beat but from a much more speculative basis, which he admits, when he suggested that:

> One day one of our distant hominid ancestors sitting on a fallen log happened to start banging on it with a stick – *boom boom, boom*. For *no good reason at all*. This was just idle diddling … mere nervous fidgeting, but the repetitive sound striking his ears just happened to feel to him a slight improvement on silence … Now introduce some other ancestors who happen to see and hear this drummer. They might … again *for no reason*, find their imitator-circuits tickled into action.

Pre-conscious learning is a much more rational reason for understanding the universality of the beat in music than Dennett's speculations and, even if his speculation has some basis, then he has still not accounted for the reason why *boom, boom, boom* is nicer than silence. Although I will argue that imitation is at the heart of early human learning, I feel that learning – especially pre-conscious learning from our own biology – is much less speculative than Dennett's conjecturing. Part of the fetus's growth process is incorporating experiences into itself in some way. We know the same from people's experiences of favourite or disliked tastes since they correspond to the mothers' experiences while the fetus was still in the womb, and so on.

Moreover, this process does not stop at birth, since the brain in which those 'learnings' are stored is not completely formed at birth:

> the orbitofrontal cortex, which is so much about being human, develops almost entirely post-natally. This part of the brain develops after birth and doesn't begin to mature to toddlerhood.

There is nothing automatic about this. Instead, the kind of brain that each baby develops is the brain that comes out of his or her particular experiences with people. It is very 'experience dependent' (Gerhardt, 2004: 37–8).

As Gerhardt goes on to note, it is hard to consider a baby developing a social dimension without being in relationship with others, and so the child enters the cultural environment early in its development, depends on significant others and learns relationship through experience. Consequently, we can see the significance of relationship at the outset of life and

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we can also see why there is a propensity to accept what we are told, or, in Gadamer's (1976) terms, we can see the significance of tradition and prejudice. Indeed, research has shown that we cannot live in isolation: in a well-known experiment at McGill University in the 1950s students were paid to spend time in complete isolation: despite the payment none lasted for 72 hours and many needed psychological help – we all need outside stimulation, or, in other words, relationship.

But it is in relationships that our learning begins and, as Gerhardt indicates, this process of learning aids and abets the growth of the brain after birth – but it is social learning, and the part of the brain that is growing is the social brain. The person, then, is always in society, and we also start learning the emotions very early in our lives – indeed, some of them are hard-wired and we have to learn how to control them! As we pointed out in the previous chapter, we do have experiences from the time of birth and we learn to memorise from sensations: Donald (2001: 75) suggests that memorising sensation is the basis of consciousness itself and that we learn consciousness in this same process. It can thus be seen that consciousness itself has evolved through learning and remembering and this same process is evident in our human development. It is the expanding brain that provides us with the opportunity of broadened experience from which we can continue to learn. Indeed, we are freed from the immediate experience and able to memorise past experiences. The basis of our learning is awareness itself – the act of experiencing – although it is attention that focuses our learning in a conscious manner.

In bringing this section to a close, we can see that we have been confronted here with the idea of pre-conscious learning: a form of learning that I first discussed in *Adult Learning in the Social Context* (Jarvis, 1987). There are, however, at least three forms of pre-conscious learning:

- One is that which occurs while the fetus is in the womb – in this case it seems that it occurs through the physical connections between mother and fetus that might, in some way, programme the brain before the birth of the mind but the outcomes of which become apparent in later conscious experiences in the person.
- A second form occurs when we have experiences the content of which we internalise, although we are concentrating and aware of specific aspects of it rather than others. Yet the other aspects of the event or episode are also internalised and are also retained in the mind although we are unaware of it – some of these aspects might be activated by subsequent experiences so that we can recall them and learn from them. If this activation does not occur fairly soon after the initial experiences the memory trace may be lost. We have all had experiences of this type when we have internalised something that has occurred in our immediate experience.
- Through the processes of social living we are constantly adjusting our behaviour to respond to the divergent elements of disjuncture and not necessarily adjusting our theories of behaviour or meaning, and we gradually gain expertise or even wisdom without realising that it has occurred, although others may recognise it in us.

It is quite possible to explain pre-conscious learning through a careful analysis of how the brain functions. The traditional view has been that the sensory organs transmit their messages to the thalamus and then to the neocortex and from there to the limbic brain. But Goleman (1995: 18), referring to the work of LeDoux informs us that:

> there is a smaller bundle of neurons that leads directly from the thalamus to the amygdala, in addition to those going through the larger path of neurons to the cortex. This smaller and shorter pathway – something like a neural back alley – allows the amygdala to receive some direct input from the senses and start a response *before* they are fully registered by the neocortex.

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LeDoux discovered that the emotional system can act independently of the neocortex or that emotional reactions do not require conscious participation. Once we accept that this pathway exists, we can understand the possibility of learning pre-consciously. Goleman (1995: 20) goes on the indicate that 'in the first few milliseconds of our perceiving something we not only unconsciously comprehend what it is but decide whether we like it or not'. In this sense we can see that certain of our emotions, perhaps our primary ones, precede rationality. But it is not only emotions but perception itself that occurs in these first milliseconds, and it is here that pre-conscious learning is to be found.

We will return to the idea of pre-conscious learning many times in this book, but it is one of the most fundamental forms of learning in the process of becoming a person starting not quite with life itself but from before birth and continuing through much of life itself after birth.

Part 2: Learning and the senses

It is clear from the above that our initial learning is from the senses and has a biological dimension to it, but it will become evident that we do not consider the idea that human beings are entirely driven by their genetic make-up (Dawkins, 1976) to be a valid proposition despite its continuing popularity as it does not produce sufficient evidence to displace child development theories (see Nelson, 2007). This does not mean that evolution should be rejected: it should not, although we need to recognise the extent of the debate when we look at human learning.

Whilst in the uterus, the fetus is already acquiring information (learning) through the senses. This process continues throughout the whole of life, but it is more complex after we have left the womb and as we grow and develop. In all experiencing and learning, the process begins with the bodily processes of sight, smell, sound, taste and touch. In itself each sense experience is meaningless, and so we need to give it meaning and name it, but this is a later process. When we can do this, and recall it, then we can begin to take our sense experiences for granted and yet still have cognitive disjunctures, but in many instances our disjuncture can begin with any of these sensations. We will all, no doubt, recall that game in which we have to guess the nature of an object from a picture taken from an unusual angle, or when we are asked to feel something that we cannot see, and say what it is. These games build on the idea of disjuncture – we cannot take the taste, touch, sight and so on for granted. Children probably have more disjunctural experiences that stem from sense experience than adults since they do not have the cognitive apparatus to give meaning to them in the first instance. It is only as we grow that we gain the knowledge necessary to cope with them.

Initially, babies have experiences, or sensations, that they do not know, and in the first instance they memorise these – and so the brain stores these sensations as early memories. But from the very earliest of days they have to distinguish between its memories and new sensations – both sensations of different phenomena and, even more difficult, sensations of the same phenomenon. Hence, they have to distinguish between the new experience and the memory of the past sensations of the same phenomenon, and this lies at the initial stages of conscious awareness. Learning, then, is memory, and memory is the reconstruction of earlier experiences. In this sense we learn to be conscious, as we suggested earlier in this chapter, but our experiences are meaningless and we have to learn to become conscious through a process of constructing and reconstructing our experiences. Indeed, for the child in its earliest of days, meaning almost certainly does not exist. Children have sense experiences that they cannot explain and so they live in ignorance, a phenomenon of which they may be unaware in the first instance. However, as they mature so they begin to give meaning to those initial sensations of sight, smell, sound, taste and touch, and their learning moves from the senses to the cognitions and the knowledge they learn from the sensations is conveyed in language and so later learning occurs primarily in the cognitive domain and the sense experiences are relegated to a secondary position. Consequently, as we mature, the more our learning assumes a cognitive dimension, but there are still times when we have a sense experience that we cannot

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explain in language – a disjunctural experience – and so we are forced to revert to the senses until we can give it meaning. In a way this was the problem that the American adult educator and populariser of the concept of andragogy, Malcolm Knowles (1970, 1980), tried to deal with when he wrote his book on *The Modern Practice of Adult Education* – the first edition he subtitled *Andragogy versus Pedagogy*, but as a result of the ensuing academic debate the revised edition was subtitled *From Pedagogy to Andragogy*. Yet he never really resolved his problem and the reason was probably because he did not distinguish learning from the senses and the emotions from learning from the cognitions, and so he was unable to clarify any relationship between children's learning and adult learning (Jarvis, 2007a). Adults continue to learn though the senses as well as through cognition and children learn cognitively from very early in their lives.

In the first instance, we can say that the initial stimulus is learned and remembered but it has no meaning: it is an S–R (stimulus–response) form of learning but there is a 'logic of meaning' underlying all experiences that later has to be satisfied. But this cannot really happen until children have acquired the capability of language. Once remembered, there is one sense in which these sensations can be taken for granted, but until we can give meaning to experiences there is another sense which forbids our taking it for granted. At the same time, there is an ongoing process of deciding whether we like or dislike the sensation which we have – and so we are learning feelings and attitudes at the same time. This process is often conscious but sometimes it is a pre-conscious experience and we decide the next time we have that sensation whether we like it or not: here, once again we can begin to see the significance of pre-conscious learning.

Once we have developed a cognitive dimension to our learning there is a sense in which the bodily aspects of learning, the senses, appear to lose a great deal of their significance. The dominance of the cognitive is natural, but the loss of the significance of the sense itself is dangerous to our humanity, and it is for this reason that we need to be slow and to be attentive to our experiences (Crawford, 2005) in order to learn the most from them. All learning begins with the sensations – even a sound or the sight of a symbol – and so we this form of learning can be depicted by Figure 3.1, which is but a simplified version of our more complex model of learning. Nevertheless, it is a model of learning from primary experience.

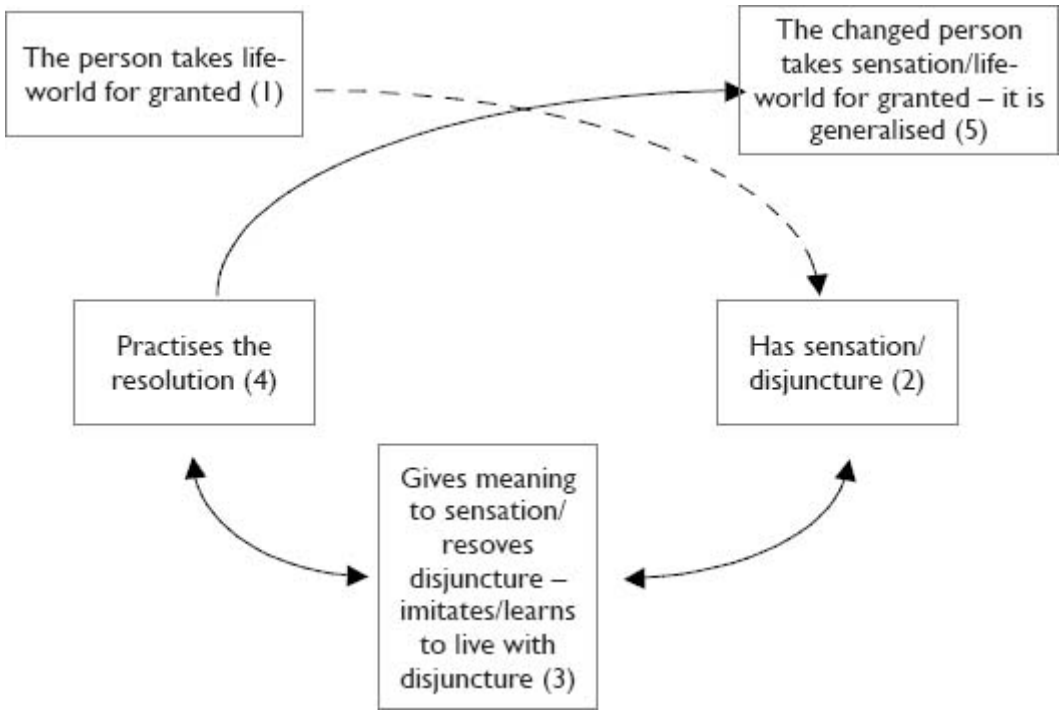


Figure 3.1 The transformation of the senses: learning from primary experience.

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In Figure 3.1, we see that the disjuncture is caused by an inability to take the sensation for granted – this may be because the sense experience is new or because it is unrecognised, as well as because we cannot give it meaning (box 2) – we will discuss the concept of meaning quite fully in a later chapter. However, the arrow to box 2 is dotted because in early childhood the disjuncture is caused not because the sensation is destroying a previously taken for granted situation, but because it is providing a completely new developmental experience. Before the acquisition of language, or at least the understanding of language, the ascription of meaning is restricted, although other language forms, such as music and shape, can also give possible meanings for the trained mind, e.g. the artist or the musician. However, this is the children's dilemma: they have to learn to give it a meaning that is their own or they adopt (imitate) the meaning given by their wider society. Subjective meaning is important, but as we grow that subjective meaning has to relate to an objective meaning that lies outside the children themselves; this is to be found in culture, which is carried by other people and which we all learn through interaction. Over time and repeated experiences, children learn that the same experience that they have memorised can be given a generalised meaning, one which is usually embedded in culture and transmitted through interaction with significant others.

The double arrows between boxes 2 and 3 and between boxes 3 and 4 indicate that the learning is trial and error, or experimental and self-directed, in as much as in the first instance the meaning fits the sensation (box 3) and, in the second, the meaning is accepted by the social group (box 4). Acceptance by the group does not mean that it is correct – only that it is socially acceptable. If the children's subjective meaning is acceptable in as much as the people with whom they interact and upon whom they practise their answer do not contradict them in some way, then they can assume it to be socially correct even though it may not be technically correct. If not, then they are faced with a new learning situation later in their lives. As they continue to practise it, so they are able to universalise it and take it for granted, until the next time that a disjunctural situation occurs. Kolb (1984) actually includes generalisation in his learning cycle, but my research suggests that generalisation occurs not immediately following a new learning experience, but only after the resolution to disjuncture has been tried out on several occasions. If children do not resolve the dilemma, then they revert to box 2 and try again, so that the arrows between boxes 2 and 3 and between boxes 3 and 4 are not unidirectional, illustrating that there is a process of trial and error learning at both stages. At the point of taking our sensations for granted, which is the basis of habitual behaviour, they move to the next phase – as we will see when we discuss meaning itself rather than the sensation. Adults and older children are more likely than young children to experience disjuncture in the cognitive domain and to take the sensation stage for granted.

Nevertheless, those theorists who want to reduce everything to sensory experience actually claim that consciousness is 'empty of meaning' (Donald, 2001: 35), and by this approach they question the whole basis of learning theory and even human existence (see Bruner's (1990) criticism of this approach). But, Pinker (1999) admits, we cannot build an autonomous robot and even Donald (2001: 135–7), who wants to discover how meaning evolved in the evolutionary process, is forced to admit that its physical basis is not yet understood. At the heart of human learning is the acquisition of meaning through interaction and cultural experience and all the studies of learning and thinking psychology and the social sciences are implicitly questioned by those who place all their bets on evolution alone. By way of contrast, other scholars who play down the significance of consciousness do so because they see it as a cultural invention perpetuated through language, but even this position is open to considerable criticism, as we will see in the following pages.

Part 3: Learning in play

Play is not just the aimless passing of time with or by children: 'simply running around without purpose or rules is boring and does not appeal to children' (Vygotsky, 1978: 103); it is incorrect to regard play as action without purpose.

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There is a clear development in the way children play, and the age of about three years is when the transition takes place (Vygotsky, 1978: 93, 97; Nelson, 2007: 99–100). Before the age of three, play serves several functions in the child's world, as summarised by Nelson (2007: 101–2):

> In summary, these various action modes – imitation, gesture, object and event play, category sorting – allow toddlers to represent their meanings, their knowledge of things and how they function in events in the child's world. The representations are external, 'in the world' and available for reviewing. They are also available for others who engage with the child and who may attempt to interpret or to share the child's meaning … they are social steps towards shared meanings that become more precise as language enters more fully into the picture.

But thereafter Vygotsky (ibid.: 93) sees play as enabling children to create imaginary situations in which unrealisable desires can be realised. But these situations are zones of proximal development because in play children always behave beyond their average age. He claims that imagination is a new psychological process which is not present in the initial consciousness of children and it is at the heart of our understanding of play. However, play produces rules of behaviour in the situation, and children are sticklers for keeping to the rules, and so play helps children develop their imagination and learn rules and self-control. But imagination is not an end in itself:

> Creating an imaginary situation can be regarded as a means of developing abstract thought. The corresponding development of rules leads to actions on the basis of which the division between work and play becomes possible.
>
> (ibid.: 103–4)

It is during this time that the division between visual situations and the visual field, i.e. between situations of thought and real situations, occurs. It is this that led the political philosopher Kingwell (2000: 68–74) to think that the universalism of imagination could be the alternative to Kant's universalism of rationality. He (ibid.: 68) defines it as 'the capacity to see beyond the materials given'. It is a sense of challenging our own personal experience and empathising with us: it is the opportunity to imagine a different and better world than the one in which we live, and in this sense it is at the heart of both empathy and desire. Kingwell also reminds us that this same imagination can lead to sadism, and so it is not intrinsically universally good. He (ibid.: 73) concludes that 'Imaginative connections remind us, as nothing else can, that we are, as citizens embedded in cultures, neither entirely free nor entirely imprisoned'.

Play, then, is crucial to children's development, but during it we develop our imagination and learn to make and keep rules, we learn self-control and it assists us in the development of abstract thought. Imagination helps us empathise with ourselves and helps us have a vision of a better world.

Part 4: Learning language

There have been many volumes written on language learning (e.g. Vygotsky, 1978, *inter alia*) and we have no intention of trying to rehearse all of these treatises here, but crucial to language learning is relationship, which Tomasello (1999) expands to the idea of joint attentional scenes that develop when infants are about nine months old – that is when infants begin to tune in to the activities of adults which are not expressly directed towards them and they begin to understand the other as an intentional agent, like themselves. Infants at this age begin to reproduce adults' intentional behaviour through imitation. Tomasello is clear that there is no evidence for hard-wiring in these situations. Tomasello (1999: 82) claims that:

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> Imitative learning of this type thus relies fundamentally on infants' tendency to identify with adults, present from an early age, and in their ability to distinguish in the actions of others the underlying goal and the different means that might be chosen to achieve it, present from nine months.

It is in these joint attentional scenes that children begin to use symbols since 'sounds become language for young children when and only when they understand that the adult is making that sound with the intention that they attend to something' (Tomasello, 1999: 101). Children then seek to imitate that sound and relate it to the type of situation in which they learned it – they recognise it as a shared symbol. The more time that children spend with their mothers between 12 and 18 months, the greater their vocabulary is likely to be because of it, and this results in a greater consciousness of the world in which the child lives.

What is clear from this discussion is that language does not precede culture but rather its development is dependent upon culture. Donald (2001: 279–80) suggests that there are several good reasons why we should start with culture in understanding language: it is consistent with our understanding of the evolving hominid brain; enculturation itself might account for a qualitative shift in human cognition; it accounts for imitative learning; it explains why language does not self-install in isolated individuals; and it gives us a means for referring language outside of itself.

Fundamentally, then, we see that language is learned in relationship through imitation and so it reflects the subculture of the child's life-world. In this sense, we can see that through various mechanisms children are socialised into their cultures and that, although we do not mirror them, there is sufficient of the image remaining for us to be located within the wide sphere.

Part 5: Socialisation

We are socialised into the culture of our life-world; as we have seen from the above discussion, socialisation is itself a series of learning processes. Berger and Luckmann (1966: 150) define primary socialisation as 'the first socialization an individual undergoes in childhood through which he becomes a member of society'. Secondary socialisation is the internalisation of institutional or institutionally based subworlds, and those who transmit the subculture are institutional functionaries and the relationship is specified by formal organisational procedures. The people with whom we interact are those functionaries – it is about relationship. Thereafter, the informal processes of acquiring that subculture continue through the everyday processes of social living and working. This means that the principles, practices and language of specific roles are learned and internalised. They (ibid.: 160) maintain that the biological limitations of humanity become decreasingly important as this process continues, but we would maintain here that both the biological and the genetic are more than they were to Berger and Luckmann. This is, of course, a return to the historic nature–nurture debate, but recent advances in brain research and evolutionary psychology mean that we have to take this work into consideration in our studies of human learning.

From birth onwards, a conscious awareness of the wider world gradually develops, and this is a learning process, but it is not all conscious learning: a great deal of pre-conscious learning still occurs, as we have already seen. It has been shown above that it is through relationship with significant others that a great deal of this learning happens, but in the contemporary world of the media it is not entirely possible to isolate the personal from the impersonal media transmissions to which we are all exposed, so that the dominant ideologies are also acquired early in life (see Jarvis, 2008).

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However, what is also learned in this process is quite fundamental to the development of the person, and significant others play an important role in this process.

> The significant others who mediate the world to him modify it in the course of mediating it. They select aspects of it in accordance with their own location in the social structure, and also by virtue of their individual biographically rooted idiosyncrasies. The social world is 'filtered' to the individual through this double selectivity.
>
> (Berger and Luckmann, 1966: 151)

Berger and Luckmann are, however, too rational in their approach, since we often hear parents say 'I don't know where (s)he learned that!' We are aware that children copy adult behaviour in joint attentional situations, and the adults may not even be aware of precisely what the children are learning: in this sense the children's learning is unintended. In the same way, what is transmitted verbally may not just reflect the social position of the significant others, it may also have resulted from the children's pre-conscious learning, and so on. What it clear is that Berger and Luckmann are correct in recognising that the social world that children learn about and participate in is actually slightly different from that of their significant others: it changes through transmission itself, and it changes again as children grow and externalise and enter into dialogue with others. This is all part of the lifelong learning process.

The significant others all treat the children in accord with their perception of the child's place in the world, that is in relation to the social location of their parents, and so on. There is no doubt a sense of conformity about this. Children begin to internalise their modified version of the social world of the significant others, and in this process of internalisation they identify with its familiarity; herein we find elements of pleasure formation. They then begin to identify with the individuals who are significant others – a relationship is born. Children recognise themselves by the way that those with whom they have identified treat them in a similar manner – they begin to identify themselves. Children learn a social identity long before they learn an individual one – this is a stage in the process. But significantly, this is an incidental process and one in which the growing sense of consciousness plays its part: it would be wrong to claim that it is all pre-conscious learning but it would be just as false to regard it all as a conscious process – consciousness emerges in the process itself.

As we grow, so our world of interaction broadens and we learn from a greater variety of people; we are also more exposed to the media and so we get an even broader, if not a global, view from quite early in our lives. This is secondary socialisation – when we learn in the school and also in leisure groups and organisations. Some scholars think that there is a third socialisation process – into work. However, this may well be regarded as an unnecessary distinction and so for heuristic purposes we will deal with them together here. This form of socialisation occurs for the remainder of our lives – it is usually the informal and non-formal learning processes that occur when we, as adults, join organisations so that when we start work in a new organisation there is first the formal induction and this is followed by the informal processes of 'learning the ropes' and becoming a member of the organisation. In fact, this is what Lave and Wenger (1991) describe in their book *Situated Learning* when they look at the process of individuals moving from the periphery of an organisation towards its centre. The organisation's subculture is learned by the initiates: socialisation is part of the process of lifelong learning and it continues late into lives as older people join new organisations, such as Universities of the Third Age, after their retirement from work.

Socialisation, in all its forms, is the process whereby we internalise the exterior world and make it our own, but we are not merely reproductions of a past generation since there are so many extraneous factors, such as the media and people from other faiths and cultures with whom we interact and from whom we learn, which results in the fact that, although there are many similarities between us, there are also differences. At least two things emerge from this discussion: (1)

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there are two realities, one which is internal and the other which is external, although the former is not a perfect reflection of the latter so that we are imperfect reproductions of our culture and of the persons with whom we interact; and (2) we are also individuals. Bourdieu (1992: 127–8), commenting upon the first of these, writes:

> Social reality exists, so to speak, twice, in things and in minds, in fields and in habitus, outside and inside of agents. And when habitus encounters a social world of which it is the produce it is like a 'fish in water': it does not feel the weight of the water, and it takes the world about itself for granted … It is because this world has produced me, because it has produced the categories of thought that I apply to it, that it appears to me as self-evident.

The idea of two realities, an internal and an external, is very significant for our understanding of the learning process. During the course of our everyday lives, the increasing congruence of these two realities brings us pleasure whereas incongruence can be unpleasant – it is disjunctural. However, we rarely reflect on the fact, or even recognise, that we are learning pleasure and displeasure in a pre-conscious manner in the course of everyday living.

That we have internalised our culture means that we are likely to reproduce it, in the same way as we ourselves are imperfect reproductions. Imperfect reproduction allows for the development of individuality, but individuality must follow relationship. Nevertheless, this also raises quite significant questions about where we should begin our study of the person in society – with the individual or with the group? Indeed, it is the question that separates Western and Eastern thought to a considerable degree since the former begins with the individual and the latter with the field or context. With the development of individuality, we can see the paradox of human being emerge, since it is individuals who are enabled both to enter into relationship and to create new ones. Existence, therefore, demands both the social and the individual – both group and person simultaneously.

Concluding discussion

The idea that 'the child is father of the man' can be seen clearly in this chapter: much of what is learned in these early years remains with us throughout our lives. All of this learning gives children the opportunity of coping with the exigencies of their lives and as they grow and learn even more so they gain a greater confidence to respond to the situations in which they find themselves – but we must not forget that we are already genetic and biological beings from the outset and so all these learning experiences are themselves affecting the predispositions with which we are born. Nevertheless, these years are an important springboard, and so we might ask, 'Are we predetermined as a result of early years learning?'. Clearly, we have seen that parts of the brain are developed and 'wired up' during these years and we learn language, play, attitudes and desires, and so on, as a result of these experiences. In many ways we are being programmed by our learning in a social context – but it is only adding to the complex brain with which we are born and building the mind which comes as a result of our learning. From now on we are confronted with a major philosophical problem – to what extent are the brain and the mind separated? – and here we enter the debate about the nature of the mind (see Dennett, 1991; Chalmers, 1996; Donald, 2001; Maslin, 2001; Feser, 2005; *inter alia*), but our programming is not totally predetermining since we do have the capacity to learn to act against our predispositions and inclinations, although we do so in a situation which might not be described as a level playing field. Nevertheless, we can see that we may not actually be as free as we wish or even as free as we think we are. In some ways this programming has restricted our freedom – but this is another philosophical debate that demands to be discussed more fully in a philosophical study of learning.

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However, one thing has become quite clear from this discussion of the early years, and that is that meaning and intentionality are already present in the child from early years and so it is necessary for us to examine the concept of meaning but, before we do this, we need to look at the way in which we continue to learn in everyday life.

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